the Palash or 'flame of the forest' (orange), a very distinctive colour that can be seen, and its wearer identified, from far away. Walking into a room full of people, a quick glance is enough to register how many people in your Regiment are present. It is expected that if anybody approaches you wearing the same colour 'lanyard', his request has to be accommodated. Regimentation has its uses in building up the cohesion and sense of belonging, so necessary in wartime. If a soldier stands and fights to the last man and last round, as did the men of Charlie Company, 13 KUMAON under Major Shaitan Singh at Rezang La in the 1962 War, it was for the izzat of the Regiment. As long as the Regimental spirit is harnessed to become a battle-winning factor, it has its uses. However, at some stage, a senior officer has to rise above this parochialism, which is why in my first address to my Officers on becoming Chief, I had categorically mentioned that I was the Chief of the entire Army and not merely of the Sikh Light Infantry, though my Regiment will forever be embedded in my heart and soul. It was time to walk the talk.

Till about the mid-1980s, officers on promotion to the rank of Brigadier used to write IA, Indian Army, after their name and not their Regiment. Thus, Colonel Keen Kumar (KUMAON) would now be Brigadier Keen Kumar (IA). The cap badge on the beret or peak cap would also become the Ashoka Symbol and not the Regimental crest, which practice continues even now. There was some logic in this and I felt that we needed to return to this system, where Brigadiers and above 'belong' to the Army and not to their Regiments. How does one initiate this process of change of a deeply ingrained tradition? The larger the organization and the stronger the tradition, the more difficult it is to bring about a change. We decided to start with our Mess Dress, which is a half-sleeved

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